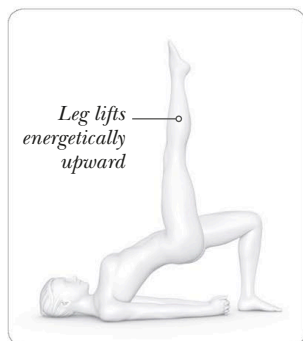


» CLOSER LOOK

Backbends like this could also be considered “heart openers,” because broadening your chest area may leave you feeling openhearted. Your glutes strengthen and tone.

**VARIATION**

To challenge your pelvic stability, try raising one leg while in Bridge pose. Engage your core muscles to support your back as you raise one leg upward. Focus on keeping your hips parallel. Press your standing foot into the floor to find support.

Hips are extended

Rectus abdominis stretches

Send knees away from torso to find length through the hips

Hips press directly upward

Heart pumps oxygenated blood around body

Lungs fill chest cavity as you inhale

Feel your ribcage expand three-dimensionally

Oxygenated blood flows to brain

Blood rush

Some claim that inversions send a rush of oxygenated blood to your head. This may happen briefly but your brain regulates its blood flow (see p.134). If you do get a head rush, come down. Backbends are called “heart openers” because they create space in your chest. Be aware of this sensation and feel your ribcage expand as you inhale.

